

Course

Introduction to Empirical Methods in Political Science

PS 210

Fall 2025

Department of Political Science
Weinberg College of Arts and Sciences

Professor

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312 Scott Hall

Office Hours Tuesdays 3-5pm

Key Dates and Times

Class meets:

Tuesday and Thursday, 9:30 to 10:50

Harris Hall L07

- Tuesday, September 23rd: Prerecorded class session.
- Thursday, October 2nd: Asynchronous activity in lieu of class meeting.
- October 9th: First homework due.
- October 16th: Midterm.
- November 7th: Second homework due.
- November 21st: Third homework due.
- Monday, December 8th, 2:00 PM: Take-home final exam due.

Basic Course Information

This course provides an introduction to the empirical methods political scientists use to answer questions about politics, and the reasons why such methods matter. After exploring how hard it is to make good descriptive and causal inferences about politics, we will examine three basic strategies for overcoming the obstacles to reliable knowledge about the political world: experimentation, large N or quantitative studies (AKA statistics), and small N studies that use qualitative reasoning.

At the end of this course, you will be able to:

- Understand and explain why descriptive and causal inference are difficult tasks in political science.
- Identify possible weaknesses in academic or other descriptive and causal claims about politics.
- Understand and explain the strengths and weaknesses of experimental research designs for causal inference about politics.
- Understand and explain the strengths and weaknesses of survey and regression-based quantitative research designs for descriptive and causal inference about politics.
- Understand and explain the strengths and weaknesses of qualitative methods for descriptive and causal inference about politics.

- Apply all of these tools to critically evaluating examples of political science research.
- Think about how empirical evidence matters to your own questions about politics.

Grades will be based on three homework assignments (30% total), a midterm (30% total), a final exam (30%), and participation (10%). Homework due dates will be set throughout the quarter. Students are encouraged to form study groups and work together but must complete and submit their own homework.

Participation (10%) – Your participation grade has three components:

- Reading Check-Ins (4%): Brief quizzes at the start of several classes to verify you’ve completed the reading. Your two lowest scores will be dropped.
- Weekly “Muddiest Point” Posts (3%): Each Wednesday by 9:00 PM, post one sentence on Canvas identifying something from the week’s materials you found confusing. Full credit for any good-faith submission.
- Engagement (3%): Active, constructive participation in class discussions, group work, and the October 2nd asynchronous activity.

Late work will be accepted but with a grade penalty equivalent to 5% per day. Late exams will not be accepted without prior communication with the instructors or an overriding exemption due to university policy.

While some of the tools discussed in this course are based in sophisticated mathematical reasoning, our discussion of them will be posed at a primarily conceptual level. While this course focuses on conceptual understanding, some topics (e.g., confidence intervals, regression) rely on basic mathematical reasoning. Students should be comfortable with high-school algebra (e.g., working with equations, interpreting graphs). No prior statistics or calculus is required.

The textbook for this course, available for free online, is *Empirical Methods in Political Science: An introduction*, edited by Jean Clipperton. That text can be found at the library’s github. The textbook will be supplemented as needed with other readings available electronically.

Research Study Participation Requirement

Students enrolled in this course are required to complete a research participation assignment. This will involve taking part in studies conducted by students and faculty from the Department of Political Science, and will include up to 4 hours of research study participation. This will primarily require completing on-line surveys, and in some cases in-person studies at Scott Hall. Students will be able to see how political science studies are conducted and can request information about the studies at the end of the quarter. Students who prefer not to participate in research may opt for an alternative that entails reading a book chapter about political science research and writing a five page reaction paper. The typical chapter is about 20 pages and thus reading it and writing a five-page paper should take approximately four hours. In order to opt for the 5-page paper alternative, please email the lab manager, Jacob Fortier at jacobfortier2027@u.northwestern.edu.

Northwestern University Syllabus Standards

This course follows the Northwestern University Syllabus Standards. Students are responsible for familiarizing themselves with this information.

Course Schedule and Readings (Fall 2026)

Sept. 24 (Thu) Topic: Asking social science questions. **Reading:** Clipperton, ed., Chapter 1.

Sept. 29 (Tue) Topic: Data. **Reading:** Clipperton, ed., Chapter 4.

Oct. 1 (Thu) Topic: Causation. **Reading:** Clipperton, ed., Chapter 2. *Note: This is the last day to add/drop courses without special permission.*

Oct. 6 (Tue) Topic: Causal inference in action. **Reading:** Morral, Andrew R., and Rosanna Smart. "Concealed Carry Laws and Violence in America." *Annual Review of Criminology* 9 (2026). <https://doi.org/10.1146/annurev-criminol-032924-013352>

Oct. 8 (Thu) Topic: Experiments. **Reading:** Clipperton, ed., Chapter 7. **Due: First homework due.**

Oct. 13 (Tue) Topic: Applied experiments. **Readings:** - Gramacho, Wladimir G., and Mathieu Turgeon. "When politics collides with public health: COVID-19 vaccine country of origin and vaccination acceptance in Brazil." *Vaccine* 39 (2021): 2608-12. - Bos, L., Schemer, C., Corbu, N., et al. "The effects of populism as a social identity frame on persuasion and mobilisation: Evidence from a 15-country experiment." *European Journal of Political Research* 59 (2020): 3-24. **Activity:** Asynchronous activity (in lieu of class meeting). See Canvas for details.

Oct. 15 (Thu) Topic: Sampling and survey research. **Reading:** Clipperton, ed., Chapter 6. **Due: Second homework due.**

Oct. 20 (Tue) Topic: Confidence intervals and significance tests. **Reading:** Clipperton, ed., Chapter 5.

Oct. 22 (Thu) Topic: Correlation and bivariate regression. **Reading:** Clipperton, ed., Chapter 8.

Oct. 27 (Tue) Topic: Multivariate regression (conceptual). **Reading:** Clipperton, ed., Chapter 8 (continued). *Note: The week of October 26-30 is when midterms are often held.*

Oct. 29 (Thu) Topic: Midterm Exam (In-person) *Note: Covers all material from Sept. 24 through Oct. 27.*

Nov. 3 (Tue) Topic: Statistical Computing Lab I: Introduction to R for descriptive statistics and visualization. (*Hands-on lab*) *Note: Students should bring a laptop with R and RStudio installed.*

Nov. 5 (Thu) Topic: Statistical Computing Lab II: Introduction to R for basic regression. (*Hands-on lab*) **Due: Third homework due.**

Nov. 10 (Tue) Topic: Machine Learning Concepts (Lecture & Demo). **Reading:** Clipperton, ed., Chapter 12.

Nov. 12 (Thu) Topic: Quantitative political science research examples. **Readings:** - Bansak, Kirk, Jens Hainmueller, and Dominik Hangartner. "How economic, humanitarian, and religious concerns shape European attitudes toward asylum seekers." *Science* (2016). Link - *Recommended:* Enos, Ryan D. "What the Demolition of Public Housing Teaches Us about the Impact of Racial Threat on Political Behavior." *American Journal of Political Science* 60 (Jan. 2016): 123-142.

Nov. 17 (Tue) Topic: The qualitative comparative method. **Reading:** Clipperton, ed., Chapter 9.

Nov. 19 (Thu) Topic: Qualitative political science research examples. **Readings:** - Gibson, Edward L. "Boundary Control: Subnational Authoritarianism in Democratic Countries." *World Politics* 58 (Oct. 2005): 101-132. - Thurston, Chloe N. "Policy Feedback in the Public-Private Welfare State: Advocacy Groups and Access to Government Homeownership Programs, 1934-1954." *Studies in American Political Development* 29 (Oct. 2015): 250-267.

Nov. 24 (Tue) Topic: Qualitative computing tools in political science. *Note: No class Thursday, Nov. 26 (Thanksgiving Break).*

Dec. 1 (Tue) Topic: Ethics and Normative Concerns in Political Science. **Reading:** American Political Science Association. (2020). *A Guide to Professional Ethics in Political Science* (3rd ed.). Chapters 1-2. [Available online via APSA website] *Recommended:* Lupia, Arthur, and Colin Elman. "Openness in Political Science: Data Access and Research Transparency." *PS: Political Science & Politics* 47 (Jan. 2014): 19-42.

Dec. 3 (Thu) Topic: Summary, review, and looking forward. **Reading:** Soss, Joe, Meghan Condon, Matthew Holleque, and Amber Wichowsky. "The Illusion of Technique: How Method-Driven Research Leads Welfare Scholarship Astray." *Social Science Quarterly* 87 (Dec. 2006): 798-807.

Final Exam: Monday, December 7, 2026, 2:00 PM (Take-home exam due).